Demonstratives Contribute Conventional Implicatures

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The standard view of demonstratives' deictic features holds that the meaning of *that man* can be glossed as *the distal man*[1] (and the meaning of *this man* as *the proximal man*). I argue for a view on which the meaning of *that man* should instead be glossed as *the man... who is distal*.

[1] Or: *The salient distal man*.

In some more detail, while demonstratives' qualitative and deictic features[2] both contribute not-at-issue contents, the former contribute to a presupposition and the latter to a conventional implicature. I propose that demonstratives are *splitsuppositional*.

[2] The terminology of "deictic" vs "qualitative" features is from Diessel (1999). Qualitative features include the nounphrase complements of complex demonstratives, as well as certain phi features, though here I only focus on the former.

1 Preliminaries: Presupposition and Conventional Implicature

(Restrictive) Presupposition A standard example of presupposition.

(1) Mary stopped smoking.
⇝ Mary used to smoke.

Conventional Implicature A classic example of conventional implicature.[3]

[3] Grice ([1975] 1989).

(2) a. Mary is poor and happy.
b. Mary is poor but happy.
⇝ Poverty interferes with happiness.

Supplemental Content Much more recent work on "conventional implicature" focuses on constructions such as non-restrictive relative clauses.[4]

[4] Spurred on by Potts (2005). See Appendix 2 below for more detail.

(3) a. Chuck killed a coworker and is in prison.
b. Chuck, who killed a coworker, is in prison.
c. Chuck who killed a coworker is in prison.

Similarities Presupposed and supplemental contents are "not-at-issue": they are difficult to deny and project past operators such as negation.[5]

[5] In the case of demonstratives:

(1) That dog is so cute!
a. ??No, it's a cat.
b. ??No, it's actually very close to us.

(2) That dog isn't a poodle.
⇝ It's not a dog.
⇝ It's not relatively distal.

Differences Restrictive presuppositions differ from supplements in that supplements are typically *novel* and the falsity of a supplement does *not* prohibit the main content from having a truth-value.

2 The Standard Presuppositional Account

The standard view of deictic features is that they contribute, alongside a demonstrative's qualitative features, to a restrictive presupposition.[6]

Version 1 "that F" presupposes that there is a unique (salient)[7] distal F, and if that presupposition is met picks out the unique distal F.

(4) $[\![that]\!] = \lambda P_{et}.\exists!x(P(x) \wedge \textsc{distal}(x)).\imath x(P(x) \wedge \textsc{distal}(x))$[8]

Version 2 Suppose instead that demonstratives are variables that receive a value from a contextually determined assignment function.[9]

(5) $$[\![x_F]\!]^c = \begin{cases} g_c(x), & \text{if } g_c(x) \text{ is distal and } F \\ \text{undefined}, & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

Version 3 A dynamic semantics treatment of demonstratives, following Stojnić et al.,[10] has it that a complex demonstrative picks up the contextually most prominent discourse referent satisfying certain restrictions. So, extending this account following the standard view of deictic features:

(6) "that man" presupposes that there is a contextually most prominent discourse referent that is for a male *and for something distal*, and if that presupposition is met picks up that discourse referent.

3 Two (and a half) Arguments Against the Standard Account

3.1 The Argument from Deictic Demonstratives

Consider the following.

(7) *Context: A speaker points at (what appears to be) a dog running through the park in front of them.*
That dog is so cute!

If the creature in question turns out to be a large cat, then it seems that the token demonstrative phrase "that dog" fails to pick out anything.[11]

In contrast, it does not seem that the creature in question must be relatively distant from the speaker in order for the token demonstrative phrase to pick out the dog. The dog might be running on the path right in front of them, or across the field fairly far away: either way 7 expresses something true or false.

[6] For various statements and refinements of this view see, see Roberts (2002), Wolter (2006), Elbourne (2008), and Ahn (2022).
[7] Following Kaplan (1989), one could add "actual" and "demonstrated" to the presupposition.

[8] Following Heim & Kratzer (1998), I take definedness conditions on the functions that are the meanings of linguistic expressions to correspond to restrictive presuppositions.

[9] See Nowak (2021) for a recent defense of this "variabilist" treatment of demonstratives.

[10] See Stojnić et al. (2013, 2017) and Stojnić (2021). Formal details building on this proposal are below in Appendix 1.

[11] And so the token sentence fails to say anything true or false. This intuition is reported by Braun (1994), Borg (2000), Glanzberg & Siegel (2006), and Elbourne (2008).

Now more thoroughly.[12]

(8) *Context: The interlocutors are at a bar, seated at a crowded table on which there are many glasses.*
   a. That cup [pointing at one glass] is mine, and that cup [pointing at another] is yours.
   b. This cup [pointing at one glass] is mine, and this cup [pointing at another] is yours.

A speaker may refer to one and then another glass with tokens of either the distal or proximal demonstratives.

In sum, deictic features contribute *non-restrictive* content whose falsity does not prohibit main content from having a truth-value. A demonstrative's noun-phrase complement, one of its qualitative features, contributes to a *restrictive* presupposition.[13]

3.2 The Argument from Anaphoric Demonstratives

Consider the following discourse.[14]

(9) A woman entered from stage left. Another woman entered from stage right. That woman was carrying a bouquet of flowers.

Observe that the demonstrative in the final sentence *must* pick up the discourse referent introduced by the indefinite in the second sentence. But if a demonstrative's deictic feature contributed to determining which discourse referent is picked up,[15] then there should be a reading where the demonstrative picks up the woman-discourse referent introduced in the first sentence.

Now more thoroughly.

(10) A woman was standing off in the distance. Another woman walked towards us.…
   a. That/This woman was smiling.
   b. #This woman was taller than that woman.

In the continuation 10a, either demonstrative must be anaphoric to the woman discourse referent introduced in the setup's second sentence. And the infelicity of 10b shows that the more recently introduced woman discourse referent must be the one picked up by an ensuing demonstrative.

[12] This data is based on that given seminally by MacLaran (1982).

[13] What about other qualitative features: phi features, such as number? I propose that either deictic features are not phi features, or phi features do not have a uniform semantics.

[14] Roberts (2002).

[15] The first two versions of the standard view do not make predictions about anaphoric demonstratives. But the third version does. Moreover, the third version can capture deictic cases. So I take Stojnić et al.'s proposal as the starting point for mine (see Appendix 1).

In sum, the argument here is as follows. Following Stojnić et al., a demonstrative's restrictive presuppositional content contributes to *determining its anaphoricity*. But deictic content does not contribute to determining its anaphoricity: if it did, the demonstratives in the continuations of 10 would be able to pick up the woman-discourse referent that is both introduced further back in discourse *and* for a woman relatively distant. Thus deictic features do not contribute to restrictive presuppositional content.

3.3 Aside on Demonstrations

Does the felicity of a deictic analog of 10b, given in 11, show that deictic features do play a restrictive role for deictic demonstratives?

(11) *Context: Again, the interlocutors are at a bar, seated at a crowded table with many glasses on it.*
This glass is mine [pointing to one glass] and that glass is yours [pointing to another].

No it does not: 8b and 8a involve occurrence of the same demonstrative type!

The felicity of 11, 8b, and 8a is due to demonstrat*ions* making one then another discourse referent maximally prominent for the ensuing demonstratives.

There *are* cases where anaphoric (and bound) demonstratives can be felicitous similarly to deictic ones.[16]

(12) A man [the speaker points to a spatial location to her left] entered from stage left. Another man [the speaker points to a spatial location to her right] entered from stage right. This man [pointing again to the left location] was happier than this man [pointing again to the right location].

(13) *Context: A developer and her assistants are inspecting a house constructed as a model for a subdivision project. They are standing in the living room.*
   a. Every house will have a light by that door [pointing to one of the doors].
   b. Every living room will have that shelf [pointing to a shelf] closer to that shelf [pointing to another shelf].

This data reveals something about the semantics of demonstrations, which requires modifying the recent accounts of both Stojnić et al. and Ebert et al. (2020), though doing so is beyond the scope of the present paper.

[16] This data is very similar to that of Schlenker (2020), which is inspired by how discourse referents are managed in sign language (see also Schlenker 2011). And the data in 13 is due to Craige Roberts (p.c.).

3.4 The "Argument" from French Demonstratives

French has the simple demonstratives "ceci" and "cela," which correspond to the English "this" and "that" used by themselves.[17]

[17] There is also the informal "ça," which I set aside.

More importantly for present purposes are the French complex demonstratives. There are two sorts, and I wish to focus particularly on the one that involves genuine or non-anaphoric nounphrase complements.[18]

[18] The other sort includes "celui-ci" and "celui-là."

When a genuine nounphrase complement is used, one of the demonstrative determiners "ce(t)" and "cette" must be used, depending on the grammatical gender of the nounphrase. Those determiners are not the definite determiners used in definite descriptions.[19] Yet, like definite determiners, they lack deictic features.

[19] Those are "le" and "la."

(14) That/This man is bald.
Cet homme est chauve.

(15) a. Cet homme-là est chauve.
That man there is bald.

b. Cet homme-ci est chauve.
This man here is bald.

Demonstrative phrases with a similar structure ("light" demonstrative and clitic after the nounphrase) are also found in certain northern Italian dialects.[20]

[20] See Ledgeway (2020), Saab & Casalicchio (2025), and Pescarini (forthcoming).

The "argument" here is that these demonstratives show more clearly, in their surface syntactic form, the two parts of English demonstratives' not-at-issue meaning that I am arguing are separate.

4 Conclusion

As observed in section 1, demonstratives' qualitative and deictic contents are not-at-issue. I proceeded to argue that qualitative features contribute to a restrictive presupposition while the deictic features do not. I thus conclude that demonstratives are *splitsuppositional*. They contribute two separate not-at-issue contents: a (restrictive) presupposition and a "conventional implicature."[21]

[21] Informally:

(1) That dog is so cute!
⇝ There is a unique (salient) dog.
⇝ That dog is relatively distal.

This proposal can be refined, taking as a starting point Stojnić et al.'s dynamic semantics account of demonstratives: "the *F*" presupposes that there is a most prominent discourse referent for an *F*-thing. I add that a demonstrative's deictic content is a *post*supposition.[22]

[22] I follow Charlow's (2022) bidimensional account of postsuppositions. For more on bidimensional semantics, see Karttunen & Peters (1979), Rooth (1985), Abusch (1994), and Potts (2005).

References

If you have trouble identifying or finding any of the works referenced above or below, please feel free to e-mail me at roryharder@gmail.com.

Appendix 1: Formalism

A context c can be modelled as an ordered pair $\langle A_c, \succeq_c \rangle$.

The first element A_c is a set of partial assignment functions or *anchors* α: functions from ω_n, the set containing the first n whole numbers, to the domain $\mathcal{D}$ of a background model $\mathcal{M}$. I write "α_n" for the element of $\mathcal{D}$ that α assigns to n. For each context c, the anchors in its A_c are all defined on the same ω_n. For a given anchor α, $|\alpha|$ is the set of whole numbers α is defined on (the set of the first n whole numbers, for some n). Then, for a given context c, we may say that $|c| = |A_c|$ is the set of whole numbers that each element anchor in A_c is defined on (which will also be the set of the first n whole numbers, for some n). Thus, $|c| = |A_c|$ is the same as the $|\alpha|$ for every $\alpha \in A_c$ (and if $A_c = \varnothing$, then $|c| = |A_c| = \varnothing$). So discourse referents can be taken to be whole numbers and $|c|$ the set of discourse referents in c.

The second element of context, $\succeq_c$, is a total[23] order on $|c|$. It exhaustively ranks a context's discourse referents.

[23] An order is *total* on a given set when it is reflexive, antisymmetric, and transitive on the given set, and such that any two elements of the given set are comparable regarding that ordering.

Expressions have a bidimensional meaning: $[\![\alpha]\!] = \left\langle [\![\alpha]\!]^1, [\![\alpha]\!]^2 \right\rangle$.

The first dimension $[\![\alpha]\!]^1$ generates at-issue updates to context; the second $[\![\alpha]\!]^2$ generates not-at-issue ones. Restrictive presupposition is understood (still) as definedness conditions on at-issue updates.

English Demonstratives

(16) a. $[\![\textit{that}]\!] = \left\langle \lambda P.\lambda c.\langle A_c, *(\succeq_c, \delta_1(P)(c))\rangle, \textsc{distal} \right\rangle$[24]

b. $[\![\textit{that}_s]\!] = \left\langle \lambda c.\langle A_c, *(\succeq_c, \delta_1(\lambda n.\textsc{t})(c))\rangle, \textsc{distal} \right\rangle$

[24] Some operations on context relied on here and below are as follows:

(1) $*(\succeq, n)$ = the $\succeq'$ such that:
   a. $|\succeq'| = |\succeq| \cup \{n\}$, and
   b. $\forall n' \in |\succeq'|(n \succeq' n')$, and
   c. $\succeq' \restriction_{|\succeq'|-\{n\}} = \succeq \restriction_{|\succeq|-\{n\}}$.

(2) $\delta_0 = \lambda c.\iota n \in |c|[\forall n' \in |c|(n \succeq_c n')]$

(3) $\delta_1 = \lambda P.\lambda c.\iota n \in |c|[P(n)(c) = c \,\&\, \forall n' \in |c|(P(n')(c) = c \rightarrow n \succeq_c n')]$

(4) $\textsc{t} = \lambda c.c$

Here are two ways that deictic content could be specified. Appendix 2 provides some considerations to help decide between them.

(17) a. $\textsc{distal} = \lambda c. \begin{cases} c, & \text{if } \forall \alpha \in A_c : \alpha_{\delta_0(c)} \in \textsc{distal}_{\mathcal{I}} \\ \text{undefined}, & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$

b. $\textsc{distal} = \lambda c.\langle \{\alpha \in A_c | \alpha_{\delta_0(c)} \in \textsc{distal}_{\mathcal{I}}\}, \succeq_c \rangle$

Predicate Meanings

(18) a. $[\![F]\!] = \left\langle \lambda n \lambda c. \langle \{\alpha \in A_c | \alpha_n \in \mathcal{I}(F)\}, \succeq_c \rangle, \text{T} \right\rangle$

b. $[\![F_h]\!] = \left\langle \lambda c. \langle \{\alpha \in A_c | \alpha_{\delta_0(c)} \in \mathcal{I}(F)\}, \succeq_c \rangle, \text{T} \right\rangle$

Rules of Composition

(19) a. When $[\![\alpha]\!]^1$ and $[\![\beta]\!]^1$ are updates:[25]

$$[\![\overset{\frown}{\alpha\ \beta}]\!] = \left\langle [\![\alpha]\!]^1 ; [\![\beta]\!]^1, [\![\alpha]\!]^2 ; [\![\beta]\!]^2 \right\rangle$$

b. When $[\![\alpha]\!]^1$ is a function that takes $[\![\beta]\!]^1$ as argument:

$$[\![\overset{\frown}{\alpha\ \beta}]\!] = \left\langle [\![\alpha]\!]^1([\![\beta]\!]^1), [\![\alpha]\!]^2 ; [\![\beta]\!]^2 \right\rangle$$

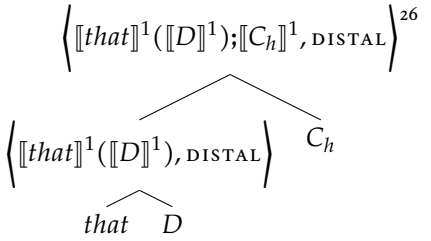
[25] The colon ; is dynamic conjunction:

(1) $[\![\alpha]\!];[\![\beta]\!] = \lambda c.[\![\beta]\!]([\![\alpha]\!](c))$

A Quasi-Tree/Derivation

(20) a. That dog is cute.

b.



[26] I omit the trivial update T throughout the derivation because it is redundant.

French Demonstratives

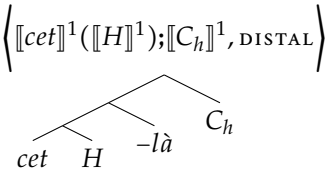
(21) a. $[\![ce(t)/cette]\!] = \left\langle \lambda P. \lambda c. \langle A_c, *(\succeq_c, \delta_1(P)(c)) \rangle, \text{T} \right\rangle$

b. $[\![-l\grave{a}]\!] = \left\langle \text{T}, \text{DISTAL} \right\rangle$

c. $[\![-ci]\!] = \left\langle \text{T}, \text{PROXIMAL} \right\rangle$

(22) a. Cet homme-là est chauve.

b.



Appendix 2: Varieties of Non-Restrictive Not-at-Issue Content

Supplemental content, unlike restrictive presupposition, has the *anti-backgrounding* property: it *must* be novel.[27]

[27] Potts (2005), page 33.

(23) a. My friend Chuck killed a coworker. #Chuck, who killed a coworker, is in prison.
b. Let me tell you about my two friends named "Chuck," one of whom killed a coworker. Chuck who killed a coworker is in prison.

But deictic content does not have the anti-backgrounding property.

(24) There is a man standing relatively far from us. That man looks sad.

There are two other sorts of (alleged)[28] non-restrictive not-at-issue content that do not have the property of anti-backgrounding.

[28] Even the category of supplemental content is "alleged."

First, there are non-restrictive presuppositions, such as that provided by "too" and "again."

(25) John came by the shop yesterday. Mary did too.

The choice of whether to treat deictic content as a supplemental content or a non-restrictive presupposition corresponds to the choice between 17a and 17b.

Finally, there is the expressive content such as that of epithets. According to Potts (2007), expressive content distinctively has the properties of *descriptive ineffability* and *repeatability*.

(26) a. My stupid asshole jerk of a neighbour wakes me up every night. The stupid asshole always has people over.
b. Stupid, stupid, stupid!

Those two further properties seem to be also had by demonstratives.

(27) a. That Henry Kissinger is a real piece of work![29]
b. That damn neighbour is at it again!

[29] Lakoff (1974).